
The Colonial Advocate

TRUTH – INDUSTRY – PATRIOTISM – REFORM

VOL. II – NO. 20 YORK, UPPER CANADA – THE SEVENTH OF MAY, IN THE YEAR 2026 PRICE: FOUR PENCE

A SECOND EXAMINATION OF THE GRAND SCHEMES OF OUR
GOVERNING GENTLEMEN

ALTO: OR, THE NINETY-BILLION DOLLAR IRON DREAM OF A GOVERNMENT THAT CANNOT MANAGE AN APP

*In which the Printer considers the Liberal Ministry's magnificent High-Speed Railway –
announced without Parliament's consent, planned without a cost-benefit analysis, and projected to
ruin the public finances of every Province save the two that shall chiefly benefit from it.*

BY WILLIAM LYON MACKENZIE – PRINTER & PUBLISHER

THE LEDGER OF BROKEN PROMISES

California's high-speed rail, approved at \$46 billion in 2008, has ballooned past \$174 billion after nearly two decades – and not one mile of track has been laid.

Britain's HS2, budgeted at £37 billion in 2015, has surpassed £100 billion in estimated costs. Its northern legs have been cancelled outright.

Canada's own Trans Mountain Pipeline expansion was estimated at \$7.4 billion. Final cost: over \$34 billion – a four-fold overrun.

ArriveCan, a simple telephone application, was commissioned for \$80,000 and delivered at a cost of \$60,000,000.

These are the hands into which the Ministry proposes to entrust ninety billions of the people's money.

 here is a particular variety of political vanity which this Printer has observed across a long life spent in the press-room and in the public arena: the vanity of the Grand Project. It is the vanity of the man who, unable to mend the leaking roof of his house, proposes instead to demolish it and construct in its place a palace — financed, naturally, upon credit, and to be completed by the time his grandchildren come of age. The present Ministry has contracted this vanity in its most acute form, and the instrument of their delusion goes by the name of ALTO.

Alto — such is the name bestowed upon the Crown corporation charged with constructing a high-speed railway from Quebec City to Toronto, with trains to travel at three hundred and twenty kilometres per hour, and the whole magnificent enterprise to be accomplished at a cost somewhere between sixty and ninety billion dollars. That the lower figure already represents the most optimistic estimate, and that every comparable project in the civilized world has exceeded its initial budget by a factor of two or three, ought to give the most enthusiastic friend of rapid transit some cause for sobriety. But sobriety is not the present fashion in Ottawa.

The project was announced — not debated in Parliament, not subjected to the scrutiny of elected representatives, not put to the people in any form — but *announced*, by the outgoing Prime Minister Trudeau in the February of last year, a few weeks before he vacated the office he had already been compelled to relinquish. A man leaving a burning house does not typically pause to commission expensive renovations; yet this departing minister saw fit to bind the public treasury to a scheme of ninety billions before handing the keys to his successor. It was, one must concede, a gesture of considerable audacity.

"A Government that spent \$60,000,000 on a telephone application budgeted at \$80,000 now asks the public to trust it with a railway costing ninety billions. Reader, at that rate of overrun, the true cost of Alto would equal the gross domestic product of the entire Dominion."

Let us now examine what, precisely, is being offered for this sum. Alto, its promoters assure us, will carry twenty-five million passengers annually. It will reduce travel time between Toronto and Montreal to three hours and seven minutes. It will boost Canada's gross domestic product

by thirty-five billions per year. These are handsome promises. But when the careful men of McGill University examined the underlying arithmetic, they found that the project will only achieve profitability – if that word may be stretched to cover the circumstance – after FIFTY-THREE BILLION DOLLARS IN PUBLIC SUBSIDY AND FORTY-FOUR YEARS OF OPERATION. Let that figure rest in the mind of the reader for a moment: fifty-three billions in subsidy. That is roughly equivalent to the entire annual revenue this government collects through the Goods and Services Tax. And the thirty-five billion dollars of annual GDP growth promised by Alto's own boosters? It amounts, upon examination, to approximately two per cent of the combined gross product of Ontario and Quebec – that is to say, roughly what those provinces are already projected to grow this year, without a dollar of rail investment whatsoever.

The Globe and Mail's editorial board, not generally noted for Revolutionary sympathies, has observed that Alto's projected benefits to travellers over sixty years of operation are pegged by the project's own administrators at approximately forty-nine billion dollars – a sum which is, in the unsparing language of arithmetic, *less than the cost of building the thing*. A railway that costs more than the total value it will ever deliver is not, by the usual standards of political economy, an investment. It is a monument. And monuments, however noble their intent, are traditionally financed by those who commission them – not by the unborn children of provinces that shall never see a single station.



This brings us to the most grievous injustice embedded in this project, and one which this Printer wishes to place before the people of the western provinces, of the Atlantic shore, and of every region of this Dominion that lies beyond the charmed corridor between Quebec City and Toronto. Alto's benefits – whatever they may prove to be – will accrue overwhelmingly to Ontario and Quebec, those two provinces which between them hold the balance of seats in Parliament and the ear of every government that has sat at Ottawa within living memory. Its costs – that is to say, the debt service on ninety billions borrowed in the name of all Canadians – will be distributed with fine democratic impartiality across every household in the land. The farmer of Saskatchewan, who shall never ride this train, shall pay for it. The fisherman of Newfoundland, a thousand miles from the nearest proposed station, shall pay for it. The working family of British Columbia, who might prefer that their federal government invest in something of relevance to

their own lives, shall pay for it.

There is a name for this arrangement in the honest language of political economy. It is called the taxation of the many for the benefit of the few, administered by a government which has never submitted this particular expenditure to Parliamentary debate, which announced it without consulting the great pension funds that might actually finance it, which has yet to release a detailed cost-benefit analysis to the public, and which is – even at this late hour – unable to say with any precision where the ninety billions will come from, beyond the general and inexhaustible source that governments have always preferred: the national credit, to be repaid by posterity.

“The benefits of Alto fall upon two provinces. Its debts fall upon thirty-eight million Canadians. This Printer calls that by its plain name: tribute.”

The Ministry’s defenders will protest that this country requires bold infrastructure investment, and that the timid counsel of accountants must not be permitted to strangle the aspirations of a nation. This Printer does not dispute the first proposition. Canada’s passenger rail service is, as any traveller will readily confirm, an embarrassment to a wealthy country. Via Rail’s trains crawl at speeds that the railways of France, Japan, and Spain surpassed forty years ago. The case for investment in rail – real investment, prudent and proportionate – is not a controversial one. But there is a profound difference between mending the leaking roof and building a palace. The government had been studying a sensible alternative for nearly a decade: High-Frequency Rail, a more modest proposal that would have placed more trains on improved existing track and served more Canadians at a fraction of the cost. It was practical, deliverable, and bore the cardinal merit of being achievable within a human lifetime. The outgoing Prime Minister set it aside in favour of Alta’s gleaming vision, as a man exchanges a reliable horse for a thoroughbred he has no stable to house and no jockey to ride.

Nor is this Printer reassured by the international comparisons with which Alta’s advocates seek to dazzle the public. Japan’s Shinkansen – that marvel of engineering and national will – connects a corridor of sixty million people across five hundred and fifteen kilometres. Alta’s core route links metropolitan populations of approximately ten millions across a comparable distance. The ridership base is, in the brute language of mathematics, one-sixth the size. California

attempted its high-speed railway; after eighteen years and costs tripled from forty-six billions to over one hundred and seventy-four, no track has been laid. Britain's HS2 has consumed over a hundred billions and been partially cancelled. Canada's own Trans Mountain Pipeline – a far simpler undertaking than a thousand kilometres of electrified railway through the varied and litigious geography of two provinces – exceeded its original budget by four hundred per cent. The government that oversaw that overrun is the government now proposing to manage Alto.



And then there is the matter of the land. Alto requires new, dedicated, and supremely straight track – for a train travelling at three hundred and twenty kilometres per hour cannot, as the Crown corporation's own Chief Executive has candidly explained, tolerate curves. It must therefore pass in a nearly undeviating line through the farms, woodlots, villages, and properties of the Quebec-Windsor corridor, acquiring whatever it needs by the ancient and sovereign power of expropriation. *"If people are reluctant,"* said Mr. Martin Imbleau, the Chief Executive of Alto, with a frankness this Printer cannot but respect for its honesty if not its charity, *"there is of course some recourse with the expropriation process."* A hundred and fifty years ago, it was the Family Compact that felt entitled to dispose of the people's land without their full and free consent. Today it wears a different coat and carries a different title, but the disposition is the same: the great project shall go forward, and those in its path may apply for compensation.

The people of the corridor communities – those citizens whose farms, properties, and livelihoods lie in Alto's projected path – organized themselves into an association and commissioned a national survey. They found that only one Canadian in four strongly supports this project, that one in five remains entirely undecided, and that the project's enthusiasts are concentrated, almost entirely, in Ontario and Quebec. They found, further, that the project was announced without consulting Parliament and without public debate. They have asked, as free citizens of a democratic country have every right to ask, for genuine consultation before expropriations proceed. Whether they shall receive it remains, at this writing, an open question.

This Printer has one final observation, and it concerns the nature of the thing itself. High-speed rail is not, in principle, an unworthy ambition. But a worthy ambition improperly executed, inadequately costed, inequitably distributed, imposed without Parliamentary mandate, and as-

signed to a government whose record of managing large public undertakings gives every rational person cause for alarm, is not a worthy ambition in practice. It is an act of hubris dressed in the language of national pride. The Ministry has spent three billion nine hundred million dollars on the planning phase alone — money already committed to a design process expected to last four to five more years, before a single spike is driven or a single passenger carried. The full construction will not be complete, on the project's own timeline, until some time between 2041 and 2044. That is, Reader, nearly two decades from today — if all goes to plan, which it will not.

The people of this country deserve a railway. They deserve one that serves them honestly, that is proportionate to the revenues available to pay for it, that does not conscript the unborn into debt for the gratification of the present Ministry's desire to be remembered as builders. They deserve one that was debated in their Parliament, costed with their scrutiny, and approved by their representatives. What they have been given, instead, is Alto: a sovereign name for a borrowed dream, a monument to the ambition of men who will be long retired — or long departed — before the first train runs, and who shall bear none of the consequences if it does not.

This Press demands what it has always demanded: the truth, the full accounts, and the consent of the governed. Nothing more, and nothing less.



The Colonial Advocate is printed and published in the spirit of William Lyon Mackenzie (1795-1861), who established the original Colonial Advocate in 1824 at Queenston, Upper Canada, and thereafter at York, where he campaigned against the oligarchy of the Family Compact and in defence of the rights and liberties of the common people of this Province. The Printer notes that he has no objection to railways per se, having observed during his own years of exile that the United States built theirs with considerably more dispatch and considerably less public debt than the current Ministry appears to contemplate. The opinions herein are those of a free press, beholden to no Ministry, no railway consortium, and no power save the conscience of its readers.